Silver Water

By Amy Bloom

(Pg 87 – 100) My sister's voice was like mountain water in a silver pitcher. After we went to [the opera], when she was fourteen and I was twelve, she elbowed me in the parking lot and said, "Check this out" And she opened her mouth wide and her voice came out, so crystalline and bright that all the departing opera-goers stood frozen by their cars, unable to take out their keys until she had finished.

That's what I like to remember . . . That before her constant tinkling of commercials and fast-food jingles there had been Puccini and Mozart and hymns so sweet you expected Jesus to come down off his cross and clap. That before there was a mountain of Thorazined fat, swaying down the halls in sweatpants, there had been the prettiest girl i Landmark Junior High. To me, Rose, my beautiful blond defender, was perfect.

INTRODUCTION

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She had her first psychotic break when she was fifteen. She had been coming home moody and tearful, then quietly beaming, then she stopped coming home. She would go out into the woods behind our house and not come in until my mother went after her and stepped into the briars and saplings and pulled her out, blank-faced, her sweater covered with crumbled leaves, her jeans smeared with dirt. After three weeks of this, my mother said to my father:

MOTHER: David, she's going crazy. She needs a hospital.

Rose was in hospitals, great and small, for the next ten years. She had lots of terrible therapists and a few good ones.

The worst family therapist we ever had sat in a pale green room with us, read Rose's file in front of us and then watched in alarm as Rose began crooning, beautifully, and slowly massaging her breasts. My mother and I laughed, and even my father started to smile. This was Rose's usual opening salvo for new therapists.

THERAPIST: I wonder why it is that everyone is so entertained by Rose behaving inappropriately.

Rose burped, and we all laughed. This was the seventh family therapist we had seen, and none of them had lasted very long.

THERAPIST: What do you think of Rose's behavior, Violet?

VIOLET: I don't know. Maybe she's trying to get you to stop talking about her in the third person.

ROSE: That was not a successful intervention, Ferret Face.

He did look like a blond ferret, and we all laughed again. The day we met our best family therapist started out almost as badly. We scared off a resident and then scared off her supervisor, who sent us Dr. Thorne. Dr. Thorne was good for us, Rose moved into a halfway house, took her meds, lost about fifty pounds, and began singing at the A.M.E. Zion Church, down the street from the halfway house.

At first they didn't know what do to with this big blond lady, dressed funny and hovering wistfully in the doorway

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during their rehearsals, but she gave them a few bars of "Precious Lord" and the choir director felt God's hand.

Rose and the choir's contralto, Addie Robicheaux, laid out their gold and silver voices and wove them together in strands as fine as silk, as strong as steel. And we wept as Rose and Addie, in their billowing garnet robes, swayed together clasping hands until the last perfect note floated up to God.

Rose would still go off from time to time and the voices would tell her to do bad things, but Dr. Thorne or Addie or my mother could usually bring her back . . . [And then] after five good years, Dr. Thorne had an aneurysm and died.

Rose stopped taking her meds, and the halfway house wouldn't keep her after she pitched a patient down the stairs. My father called the insurance company and found out that Rose's new psychiatric coverage wouldn't begin for forty-five days. I put all of her stuff in a garbage bag, and we walked out of the halfway house.

My father convened a family meeting:

FATHER: This is going to be difficult--not all bad, but difficult--for the whole family, and I thought we should discuss everybody's expectations. I know I have some concerns.

ROSE: *(with lowered eyes, as she frantically pulled at her clothing)* No meds!

My father looked in despair at my mother.

MOTHER: Rosie, do you want to drive the new car?

ROSE: *(face lighting up, she speaks manically)* I'd love to drive that car, I'd drive to California, I'd go see the bears at the San Diego Zoo, would take you, Violet, but you always hated the zoo. Remember how she cried at the Bronx Zoo when she found out that the animals didn't get to go home at closing?

MOTHER: If you take your medication, after a while you'll be able to drive the car. That's the deal. Meds, car.

ROSE: You got yourself a deal, darlin'.

I was living about an hour away then, teaching English. I went home every few days for dinner. I called every night:

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FATHER: *(On the phone, quietly)* It's very hard. We're doing all right, I think, Rose has been walking in the mornings with your mother and she watches a lot of TV. She won't go to the day hospital, and she won't go back to the choir. I'm sorry, sweetheart, don't mean to depress you.

I stayed away all week, afraid to pick up my phone. On Sunday, I came in the early afternoon, to help my father garden. We weeded and staked tomatoes while my mother and Rose were down at the Lake. I didn't even go into the house until four, when I needed a glass of water. Someone had broken the piano bench into five neatly stacked pieces and placed them where the piano bench usually was.

FATHER: We were having such a nice time, I couldn't bear to bring it up.

VIOLET: What did Mommy say?

FATHER: She said, 'Better the bench than the piano.' And your sister lay down on the floor and just wept. Then your mother took her down to the lake. This can't go on, Vi. We have twenty-seven days left, your mother gets no sleep because Rose doesn't sleep, and if I could just pay twenty-

seven thousand dollars to keep her in the hospital until the insurance takes over, I'd do it.

VIOLET: All right. Do it. Pay the money and take her back.

FATHER: I would if I could. The policy states that she must be symptom-free for at least forty-five days before her coverage begins. Symptom-free means no hospitalization.

VIOLET: Jesus, Daddy . . . She hasn't been symptom-free for forty-five minutes.

FATHER: It's the only one I could get for long-term psychiatric. *(near tears, he places his hand over his mouth, to block whatever he was about to say, and goes back out to the garden).*

He stayed outside and I stayed inside. Rose and my mother came home from the lake. My mother kissed me lightly and told Rose to go up to her room and change out of her wet pants.

ROSE: *(eyes growing very wide)* Never. I will never. . .! *(Begins rocking violently)*

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She knelt down and began banging her head on the kitchen floor with rhythmic intensity, throwing all her weight behind each attack. My mother put her arms around Rose's waist and tried to hold her back. Rose shook her off, not even looking around to see what was slowing her down.

MOTHER: Violet, please . . .

I threw myself onto the kitchen floor, becoming the spot that Rose was smacking her head against. She stopped a fraction of an inch short of my stomach.

ROSE: *(stopping her violent rocking)* Oh Vi, Mommy, I'm sorry. I'm sorry don't hate me! *(she rushes from the room wailing)*

Dinner was filled with all of our starts and stops and Rose's desperate efforts to control herself. She could barely eat and hummed the McDonald's theme song over and over again, pausing only to spill her juice down the front of her smock and begin weeping.

ROSE: *(Rocking and chanting)* I want to go to bed, I want to go to bed and be in my head. I want to go to bed and be in my bed and in my head and and and and . . . .

FATHER: Okay, okay, Rose. It's okay. I'll go upstairs with you and you can get ready for bed. Then Mommy will come up and say good night too. It's okay, Rose.

My father reached out his hand and Rose grasped it, and they walked out of the dining room together, his arm around her middle. [A short time later] my father came into the kitchen and signaled to my mother. They went upstairs and came back down together and we went to sit on the porch and listen to the crickets. I don't remember the rest of the evening, but I remember it as quietly sad, and I remember the rare sight of my parents holding hands, sitting on the picnic table, watching the sunset.

I woke up at three o'clock in the morning. I went down the hall and looked into Rose's room, for no reason. She wasn't there. I could feel her absence. I went outside and saw her wide, draggy footprints darkening the wet grass into the woods.

VIOLET: *(in a loud whisper)* Rosie. Rosie, it's me. Are you here? Are you all right?"

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I almost fell over her. Huge and white in the moonlight, her flowered smock bleached in the light and shadow, her sweatpants now completely wet. Her head was flung back, her white, white neck exposed like a lost Greek column. Her breathing was very slow, and her lips were not as pink as they usually were. Her eyelids fluttered.

ROSE: *(whispering)* Closing time . . .

I believe that's what she said. *(Long beat)* I sat with her, uncovering the bottle of Seconal by her hand, and watched the stars fade. When [they] were invisible and the sun was warming the air, I went back to the house. My mother was standing on the porch, wrapped in a blanket, watching me.

MOTHER: Warrior queens . . . I raised warrior queens.

She kissed me fiercely and went into the woods by herself. Later in the morning she woke my father, who could not go into the woods, and still later she called the police and the funeral parlor. She hung up the phone, lay down, and didn't get back out of bed until the day of the funeral. *(Long beat)*

My mother played the piano and Addie sang her pure gold notes and I closed my eyes and saw my sister, fourteen years old, lion's mane thrown back and eyes tightly closed against the glare of the parking lot lights.

(Quietly sing first stanza of "Precious Lord, Take My Hand" hymn; Lyrics and Music by Thomas A. Dorsey)

Precious Lord, take my hand

Lead me on, let me stand

I'm tired, I'm weak, I'm lone

Through the storm, through the night

Lead me on to the light

Take my hand precious Lord, lead me home.

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=fRGTR_wUje8

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